

7.3 E-mail Netiquette 101

The following article teaches the dos and don'ts when receiving or sending e-mail. Many users new to e-mail, are completely unaware of the unwritten rules of e-mail etiquette (commonly called netiquette) and some of the popular acronyms and "emoticons" >) used to quickly convey a message or emotion with electronic mail.

This article is not about the mechanics of sending e-mail - which buttons to push or how to do a file attachment. Those details are different for every different e-mail software package, and are better handled by manuals for each respective program. Instead, we will focus on the content of an e-mail message: how to say what you need to say. This article can be extremely beneficial for e-mail newbies whose inexperience often create wordy letters and take too much company time in conveying a simple message to others.

What Makes E-mail Different?

Electronic communication, because of its speed and broadcasting ability, is fundamentally different from paper-based communication. Because the turnaround time can be so fast, e-mail is more conversational than traditional paper-based media.

In a paper document, it is absolutely essential to make everything completely clear and unambiguous because your audience may not have a chance to ask for clarification. With e-mail documents, your recipient can ask questions immediately. E-mail thus tends, like conversational speech, to be sloppier than communications on paper.

This is not always bad. It makes little sense to slave over a message for hours, making sure that your spelling is faultless, your words eloquent, and your grammar beyond reproach, if the point of the message is to tell your co-worker that you are ready to go to lunch.

However, your correspondent also won't have normal status cues such as dress, diction, or dialect, so may make assumptions